



Scenario video: Problem-solving

Okay Sally, can you please tell me about a time when you dealt with an unexpected challenge at work? Of course. In retail, all sorts of problems can show up out of nowhere, which I'm sure is the case for a lot of other industries as well. But there's this one time I was working in a store as a sales clerk and then an extremely unhappy customer came in. She was really unhappy about a recent purchase she made on an exercise bike and demanded someone go to her car, retrieve the bike, and give her a refund. I explained that I'd be happy to provide a refund, but I wanted to learn more about what happened so we could potentially salvage the situation. I asked her if there was something wrong with the bike and she told me it was difficult for her to clip into and out of the bike with her cycling shoes.

She was upset because she spent so much money on a bike that couldn't do what all exercise bikes should be able to do. But upon further examination, turns out she was wearing the wrong sized shoes. Yes, that is the problem. Absolutely. We got her a new pair of the right sized shoes and to double-check I walked her over to one of our display bikes, the same model that she purchased. I had her go on the bike to try it out. But she was unable to click in and out of the bike as we expected, and then I noticed the issue. The clips themselves were incompatible with the shoes. This was a manufacturing issue rather than a user error. I apologize to the customer. I informed my manager. Then called the bike manufacturer to let them know that defect right away. They issued a recall immediately and asked for the customer. I offered her two options.

One, we can take that back and issue her a refund immediately. But the problem with this is, she would be without a bike, which is what she originally wanted. Number 2, the other option was to offer her a voucher for any bike in the store, as well as a free pair of

cycling shoes that we ensured would fit into the bike clips. After discussing these possible solutions with both my manager and the customer, she chose the second option. The result was a happy customer this time who despite coming into our store really angry, left the store extremely satisfied. My manager was also very pleased because a happy customer is a customer who is going to return. Wow, and what went through your thought process as you were trying to solve this problem?

Well, first, I had to assess what the actual problem was. Did the customer simply not like the product, or was there a deeper issue that had a possible solution? After I figured out what her issue was with the shoes, I had to figure out the why. Why did her shoes not fit into something they were designed to fit? After that resolved it was a matter of coming up with solutions that would make the customer happy. Is that typical for how you usually approach problems? Yeah. Pretty much, obviously every problem's a little different.

So I adjust my approach accordingly. Generally, I just like to use empathy whenever possible to understand the context. Then find the root cause and map out a couple of solutions to choose from. Well, that's really great work, Sally. You used both critical thinking and problem-solving abilities, which is what you'd need to constantly succeed as a data analyst.